Chapter 21

Action Dispatch and Action Controller

Action Pack lies at the heart of Rails applications. It consists of three Ruby modules: `ActionDispatch`, `ActionController`, and `ActionView`. Action Dispatch routes requests to controllers. Action Controller converts requests into responses. Action View is used by Action Controller to format those responses.

As a concrete example, in the Depot application, we routed the root of the site (/) to the `index` method of the `StoreController`. At the completion of that method, the template in `app/views/store/index.html.erb` was rendered. Each of these activities was orchestrated by modules in the Action Pack component.

Working together, these three submodules provide support for processing incoming requests and generating outgoing responses. In this chapter, we'll look at both Action Dispatch and Action Controller. In the next chapter, we'll cover Action View.

When we looked at Active Record, we saw it could be used as a freestanding library; we can use Active Record as part of a nonweb Ruby application. Action Pack is different. Although it's possible to use it directly as a framework, you probably won't. Instead, you'll take advantage of the tight integration offered by Rails. Components such as Action Controller, Action View, and Active Record handle the processing of requests, and the Rails environment knits them together into a coherent (and easy-to-use) whole. For that reason, we'll describe Action Controller in the context of Rails. Let's start by looking at how Rails